At a routine session of the Politburo after Brandt's resignation, harsh criticism was voiced against the Ministry of State Security. According to Der Spiegel, 'people in the know in East Berlin' claimed that Erich Mielke was 'called on the carpet',9 and Horst Sindermann, the pallid premier, complained he would face a barrage of 'unpleasant words' on an upcoming trip to Moscow. In the final reckoning, the Guillaume affair entailed no personnel consequences for the MfS but Soviet thoughts about the debacle took on a less trusting edge. The KGB was never quite sure whether the SED leadership used Guillaume as a suitable lever for toppling Brandt, who remained extremely popular in the GDR. After all, according to Der Spiegel, SED public opinion polls showed nearly 80 per cent of East Germans regarded Brandt as having genuine peace intentions and sought good relations. With Brandt in the wilderness, Brezhnev was livid at the loss of a reliable détente partner and forced Honecker to stop intelligence agents from causing trouble for politicians that had rendered 'excellent service for inter-German relationships.'

Despite a bitter aftertaste, Bonn's investigations into Guillaume's activities revealed no startling revelations. For his part, Markus Wolf admitted the affair was one of the biggest mistakes of the East German secret service. 'Our role in bringing down Brandt was equivalent to kicking a football into our own net,' he lamented. 'We never desired, planned nor welcomed his political demise.' Completely unrepentant, Guillaume was sentenced to thirteen years in prison and released in 1981 as part of an exchange of agents in the GDR. With Honecker's wholehearted backing, he was promoted, awarded medals and an honorary doctorate.

Meanwhile, Willy Brandt was succeeded by 55-year-old Helmut Schmidt, the former Finance Minister – who, despite his pose of tired-weariness – was a man of immense charisma. Hoping to open relations quickly, Honecker declared: 'We are ready now, as before, to continue our constructive policy of peace and lessening of tension that in the future will have a positive influence on the relations between the German Democratic Republic and the Federal Republic of Germany.'10 Evidence suggests, however, that Schmidt was in no hurry to engage with the GDR.